Fazl, some 500 buildings were added ‘in the fine styles of Bengal and Gujarat’. Apart from supervising these construction works, Akbar continued to hunt and, now, to play polo. He had devised a way to play the game even after nightfall, by using a ball made of the dhak or palas tree, which smouldered once it was lit, allowing for a glimmering, smoky light between the thundering hooves. Courtiers were all required to play the game and when one nobleman demurred, reluctant to join in this admittedly dangerous pastime, he was roundly censured. For polo playing, like many other aspects of Mughal social life, was a visible reminder of a cherished and heroic past, the Central Asian inheritance that Akbar was a proud claimant of, the same heroism that was narrated repeatedly in the *Hamzanama*.

Agra was now a city that was about to enter its full resplendence. Already in the time of Babur, orders had been given to his noblemen to build riverfront garden residences in the Persian style so beloved of Babur. The heart of Agra lay in these gardens lining the banks of the Yamuna on either side, the pavilions of the Mughal family, and the great noblemen of the empire. The houses of the rich, wrote Monserrate, had ‘ornamental gardens in their courtyards and tanks and fishponds which are lined with tiles of various colours’. Their roofs and ceilings were decorated with carvings and paintings but there were no windows looking out ‘on account of the filth of the streets’. The true beauty of these river-front gardens was to be admired from the gently flowing river, from where one could admire the fruit trees and the flowers, the dense green trees, and the fluttering brocade tents. The homes of the simpler folk, merchants and the like, were made of brick or stone, or mud covered with a brilliant white plaster, much admired by foreign travellers. Writing in this very year, the chronicler Muhammad Arif wrote of a cosmopolitan city, its riches attracting people from around the world. ‘The multitude of foreigners from all sorts of nations, from the corners of the four sides of the world,’ he wrote, ‘have gathered for trade and fulfillment of necessities, in such a country that the capital city of Agra has become all of India.’

♦

Far away in the kingdom of Naples, meanwhile, a young nobleman, Rudolf Acquaviva, was dreaming of angels and Hindustan. Born into the famously saintly family of Atri, young Rudolf spent his childhood praying on the damp and cold stone floors of his castle’s chapel till ulcers formed on his